

of the Enchanter

ughal era. A story woven out of the grey strands of history reduces the distance between East and West.

By S. Prasannarajan

The arrival was on the stroke of midnight, and "thanks to the occult tyrannies of those blandly saluting clocks," he had been "mysteriously handcuffed to history", his destinies chained to his country's. He would "become heavily embroiled in Fate—at the best of times a dangerous sort of involvement." That was more than 25 years ago, and when Saleem Sinai introduced himself to the literary

world, it was an astonishment, a subversion, and of course, a redemption. Choreographed by memory, watched by the restless ghosts of history, Saleem's picaresque in *Midnight's Children* was a bravura performance in imagination—the whirl of a literary dervish. Salman Rushdie, then only a few months older than his protagonist, rewrote India—and the art of the novel as it was practised in the English-speaking world. There he was, a

searing new voice resonant with the madness and the magic of the tropics, rearing to go farther, beyond the intimacies of Bombay, the city of his birth, in pursuit of the passions and perversions of the bigger world. He would return, he would bid heartbroken farewell, and then he would come back again. In the rustle of his pages, we would hear the eternity of homecoming even as the original Bombay *chakra* went on to discover—and argue with—the world.

So we saw him in some of the fabulous destinations of fiction. He would go to someplace like Pakistan to bring out the shame of power (*Shame*). He would travel all the way to Jahilia, the city of sand, to meditate on transmigrations, loss of faith—and death (*The Satanic Verses*). In *The Moor's Last Sigh*, he would leap from the black pepper-flavoured Fort Cochin to Bombay ("the bastard child of a Portuguese-English wedding, and yet the most Indian of Indian cities...an ocean of stories; we were all its narrators, and everybody talked at once") to Andalusia to chronicle the fall of a dynasty. Bombay, London and New York (also a guest appearance by the tequila country) would provide the backdrop to his

rock 'n' roll novel which is also a retelling of the romance of Orpheus and Eurydice (*The Ground Beneath Her Feet*). In *Fury*, a historian of ideas and an irascible dollmaker would give himself to fury—"the terrifying human animal in us"—in New York, the novelist's Bombay in the West. The last time we saw him, Rushdie was at the ruins of his

ancestral site, Kashmir, a memory savaged by the state and the fanatic, but to complete the homecoming saga, he needed two equally absorbing places, Los Angeles and Strasbourg (*Shalimar the Clown*). Few such journeys—action-packed, ideas-rich—are undertaken in fiction.

Somewhere along the way, he would become a character in his own imagination. He would get trapped inside a metaphor. It would become his word against the Word. In *The Satanic Verses*, there is an Imam, in exile, who wants to make a revolution, a revolt against history, which is "the blood-wine that must no longer be drunk...the intoxicant, the creation and possession of the Devil, of the great Shaitan, the greatest of the lies—progress, science, rights..." The imam would step out of the pages, and to sustain the

